

After the Story: Even the Wind and the Sea

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A companion study to *What Came Up the Riser*

Back to the Ellen Kay

Go back out with me to the Gulf of Mexico on the night of September 7, 1974. A jackup drilling rig called the Ellen Kay is standing on three steel legs in ninety feet of water, seventy miles south of Terrebonne Bay, and Hurricane Carmen is coming. The last helicopter has waved off and gone back to Houma. Four men are left aboard: Hollis Kane, the sour toolpusher from Beaumont; Dewey Lanclos, the driller who swears in two languages; Remy Guidry, nineteen years old on his first hitch; and Ellis Ware, the fifty-eight-year-old cook from Morgan City who sings old church songs over the pots and keeps a fat Bible with a rubber band around it by the coffee urn.

You remember how it went. Around midnight a knocking comes up the riser, the steel pipe that runs from the blowout preventer down through the water into the mud. Two seconds apart, louder and higher, like a man climbing stairs. Hollis puts a flashlight down the hole and there it is, a gray living thing thick as an oil drum wound around the pipe, plated in scales the size of hubcaps, with a head like a horse's skull and yellow eyes. It wraps the stack and squeezes. A hydraulic hose tears loose. The pressure gauge starts to climb toward a blowout that would kill all four of them.

The only way to save the rig is two big iron hand wheels down on the cellar deck, sixty turns apiece, an arm's length from the coils. Hollis sends Remy because he is the skinniest. Ellis says, "I'm going with the boy." He tapes down the intercom button and makes Dewey sing the anchor song into it. Then he wades out into the flashlight beam, holds up his closed Bible like a flagman's flag, and tells the thing, in the name of Jesus Christ, to be still. And it is still.

A wave knocks Ellis into the coils. Remy has one wheel left, and Ellis tells him calm as supper, "Turn the wheel, Remy." Remy turns it with bleeding hands and yells the only words he knows, words he just heard a cook say, knowing while he yells them that they are worth the breath only if the Man they name is who Ellis says He is. The thing lets go and slides back down into the

dark. The rams lock. Then the wind stops all at once and there are stars over the derrick. Hollis calls it the eye. A week later the newspaper map shows the eye came ashore sixty miles west. They were never in the eye.

On Monday morning, Hollis turns his coffee cup around and around and asks, "Who were you talking to down there?"

That is the question tonight. It is the oldest question in the Gospels, and every person on that rig had to answer it for himself.

Questions to Sit With

1. Read Mark 4:35-41. Jesus is asleep in the stern of a boat while a windstorm fills it with water. The disciples wake Him, He rebukes the wind and tells the sea, Peace, be still, and the wind stops and there is a great calm. Then the disciples are more afraid than they were in the storm, and they ask one another who this is, that even the wind and the sea obey Him. Why do you think the calm frightened them more than the storm? What did Hollis Kane feel at the doghouse window when the stars came out?
2. Read Job 41, Psalm 74:13-14, and Isaiah 27:1, where Scripture speaks of Leviathan, the great beast of the sea, as a creature only God can master. Then read Matthew 14:22-33, where Jesus walks on the water and Peter sinks when he looks at the wind. Ellis told the thing, "I serve the One who walked on your water." What does it mean that the sea and everything in it already has a Master?
3. Read Acts 19:13-16, where seven sons of a man named Sceva try to use the name of Jesus like a magic word on a demon they have no business with, and the man with the demon beats them and sends them running. Remy yelled "In the name of Jesus Christ" knowing the words were only worth the breath if the Man was real. What is the difference between saying a name and trusting a Person?

The Teaching: Who Is This?

Start where the story starts. With a chain binder and a pipe rack and a helicopter waving off in the rain. Four men on a steel island with a well under them and a hurricane coming. Every tool on the Ellen Kay was built by men who trusted the laws of pressure and steel. The blowout

preventer, the rams, the hand wheels, the choke. The whole rig runs on knowing what things are and what they will do.

That is why Hollis's question in the galley is the right one. He wants to know what he is dealing with. Who was Ellis talking to?

Josh McDowell and his son Sean McDowell build a whole chapter of *More Than a Carpenter* around that question, and they do not let us wriggle out of it. "Jesus claimed to be God, and to him it was of fundamental importance that men and women believed him to be who he was." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?). They go on: "Either we believe him, or we don't. He didn't leave us any wiggle room for in-between, watered-down alternatives." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?).

Ellis stood on that same ground in knee-deep salt water. The words he chose were a claim about who Jesus is: "He told the sea to be still, and it was still." Either that is true or it is false. If it is false, Ellis was standing in front of a monster holding up a book full of empty hope. If it is true, the thing on the riser had a Master, and the Master had a name.

The McDowells walk through the options plainly. If Jesus claimed to be God and knew He was not, He was a liar, and a liar who sent His followers to die for a lie. But they point out that the life does not fit the charge. "Someone who lived as Jesus lived, taught as Jesus taught, and died as Jesus died could not have been a liar." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?).

Then the second option. Maybe He believed it and was wrong. The McDowells admit the possibility honestly: "After all, it's possible to be both sincere and wrong." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?). But a man who sincerely and wrongly believed himself to be God, in a nation that would stone a man for saying so, would not be a sound teacher. He would be badly out of his mind. And nobody who reads the Gospels comes away thinking the Sermon on the Mount was written by a madman.

So we come to the third. The McDowells quote C. S. Lewis, who put the choice as hard as anyone ever has: "You can shut Him up for a fool, you can spit at Him and kill Him as a demon, or you can fall at His feet and call Him Lord and God." (C. S. Lewis, quoted in McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?). And then the McDowells close the door on the easy

way out: "You cannot put him on the shelf merely as a great moral teacher or a prophet."
(McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?).

Now look at the four men on the Ellen Kay through that window.

Ellis answered the question a long time before Carmen. You can see it in how he lived. He fed the boy who mocked him an extra pork chop and never said a word about it. He sang through the storm because the song was true to him. When the moment came, he waded out with no weapon but a closed Bible and a Name, and he talked to that thing in the same voice he used to call supper. Ellis was a man who had met a Person and trusted Him enough to stand in front of a sea monster, and no part of his life looks like a liar's or a madman's.

Remy answered it in the water. He had not prayed since his grandmother's funeral. He did not have Ellis's years. He did have Ellis's example, and he had the plain logic the McDowell's lay out: the words he yelled were worth the breath only if the Man was who Ellis said He was. That is why the sons of Sceva in Acts 19 got beaten and Remy did not. They were using a name. Remy was trusting a Person, and he finished the work with his hands on the wheel while he did it.

Dewey answered it halfway, the way a lot of us do. He sang the anchor song into the squawk box, bad and too fast, a man who had not been in church since his wedding. He kept singing it after the rams locked. He called Remy every September seventh for forty-five years. The story does not tell us more, and neither will we.

And Hollis turned his coffee cup around and around and walked out on deck alone. The story never tells us what he answered. The McDowell's would say that is the most important thing in his life, and maybe in ours: "Your decision about Jesus must be more than an idle intellectual exercise." (McDowell and McDowell, ch. 3 Lord, Liar, or Lunatic?). Hollis saw the thing stop at the Name. He saw the wind quit with no eye overhead. He heard a cook tell him his turn was coming.

Notice one more thing. The story gives Hollis a natural explanation, the eye of the storm, and then takes it away a week later with a newspaper map. That is how evidence often works. It leaves every man's hand free and keeps closing the side doors until the question in the galley is the only one left. Who is this, that even the wind and the sea obey Him?

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about Ellis. Who in your life has been an Ellis for you, someone whose faith you mocked or ignored, who kept feeding you anyway? Remy carried that pork chop shame every breakfast. Is there someone you need to thank, or apologize to, while you still can?

Talk about the anchor song. Ellis sang "Will your anchor hold in the storms of life" over the pots for two years while the men complained. Read Hebrews 6:19, where our hope is called an anchor of the soul, sure and steadfast. Dewey could not stop singing it once he started. What songs or Scriptures have you heard so often you stopped hearing them? What would it take to sing one of them into the squawk box when the knocking starts?

Talk about Hollis. He is the most honest man in the story in one way. He asks the real question. Then he walks out on deck before anybody can make him answer it. Where are you standing on that deck right now? What is the side door you keep using, the eye of the storm you keep pointing at, so you do not have to answer?

Talk about Remy's yell. He did not have polished words. He had a cook's words and a breaking heart and a wheel to turn. If you have never prayed out loud, what would your first yell be? If you have prayed a long time, are you trusting the Person, or just saying the Name?

Try this, this week. Read Mark 4:35-41, Matthew 14:22-33, Acts 19:13-16, Matthew 16:15, and Hebrews 6:19 out loud, slow, with a pencil in your hand. At the top of a page write WHO IS THIS? Under it write three words in a column: LIAR, LUNATIC, LORD. Next to each one, write honestly what it would mean for your life if that one were true. Then do what Hollis had not done yet on Monday morning. Answer the question. Answer it out loud, to God, in your own plain words, bad and too fast if that is all you have. Then get your hands on the wheel in front of you and turn it.

Works Cited

McDowell, Josh, and Sean McDowell. *More Than a Carpenter*. Revised and updated edition. Carol Stream, IL: Tyndale House Publishers, 2009.